

What is the environmental argument against ChatGPT?

Posted by u/deezzzznutz69420 • 0 points • 14 comments

I've seen so many people argue against ChatGPT using the argument, it destroys the environment. Nowadays if I just regularly google something, the first thing it does is give me an AI overview. How is that any different? What is the environmental reason i should type something simple into Google instead of ChatGPT if the answer will be AI either way?

Comments

u/abyssazaur • 1 points • 2025-05-12 19:03 UTC

The internet as you know it takes not too much energy. Fetching a web page is a low energy task. When an LLM "thinks" for a few seconds, that's a pretty high energy task. So the internet becoming LLM-ified means a lot more energy goes into serving the internet.

That being said -- people just have negative sentiment about AI so all they see is its environmental cost. If it actually adds value to the economy then we have a bigger, better economy with more people being productive and hopefully it even helps us address climate-caused problems. De-growth is not the solution to climate. If it doesn't add value to the economy then we'll have a recession and also people will just stop deploying it everywhere and the cost goes away.

u/crivtox • 1 points • 2025-05-27 16:38 UTC

Its not really a lot of energy.

Things like watching YouTube video actually consume a lot more energy than typical LLM usage. Google already added summaries to their search and that didn't suddenly make the internet consume x10 more energy.

It made search cost more , but the cost of search just wasn't very big compared to other things that internet does .

<https://andymasley.substack.com/p/individual-ai-use-is-not-bad-for>

People have just been misinformed by articles that are like actively trying to mislead people with faulty comparisons or talking about future energy cost of the whole AI industry as if it was current and mainly due to chatgpt .

I mean the cost is growing and it might be a big problem on the future , but having people be afraid of using Google because the AI summary might be terrible for the environment is just wrong .

u/themadscott • 1 points • 2025-05-12 16:19 UTC

There is no environmental argument specifically against chatgpt. The argument is against all AI.

u/DiogenesKuon • 1 points • 2025-05-12 16:08 UTC

LLMs as of right now aren't in any way destroying the environment any more than normal daily human activity. A LLM query uses somewhere around the amount of energy an LED lightbulb does by being on for 90 seconds. So forget to turn a light off before going to bed and that's 320 queries worth of environmental destruction you just unleashed. The problem doesn't come from individuals using ChatGPT a couple of times a day on random queries. The problem is that LLMs are significantly more energy intensive (around 10x or more) than an activity like looking something up on wiki or doing a google search (before google started to add AI results as well). So the problem comes when AI start to be considered a replacement for much more energy efficient computer exercises, and gets included in a bunch of products that don't really need to be using ai in the first place. We are also increasing the complexity of what is a "query", with chain of thought and research mode increasing the complexity and therefore cost. So massively increasing the amount of LLM based work we do could have an environmental impact.

u/Concise_Pirate • 2 points • 2025-05-12 15:33 UTC

A query on this kind of system currently uses 10 or 20 times the power of an ordinary Google search. The power is often generated in ways that aren't good for the environment.

u/crivtox • 1 points • 2025-05-27 16:25 UTC

The thing is thats actually a pretty tiny amount of electricity and people are just wrong that chatgpt(as oposed to the whole AI industry) has a big enviromental impact .

I mean even not knowing much you should be able to realize that nobody would have complained about people doing 10-20 google searches .

Watching Netflix costs orders of magnitude more energy fe.

This post explains It better .

<https://andymasley.substack.com/p/individual-ai-use-is-not-bad-for>

u/FlakTotem • 2 points • 2025-05-12 15:05 UTC

There are two takes on this;

1; It uses a TON of electricity and by extension water to power all of the requests, and the demand of that energy has a environmental impact via the use of fuel or creation of components to supply it. As those requests are being put through a processor intensive AI model instead of a more efficient one, that means more than google.

2; It also raises productivity for a lot of people. Which arguably leads to more wealth, and better ways to solve problems as the tech improves. Such as improving the environment.

u/Kitchner • 4 points • 2025-05-12 15:02 UTC

When people say "ChatGPT is actually bad for the environment you know" they are actually saying "Generative AI LLMs like ChatGPT are bad for the environment you know".

Not only do they use a huge amount of electricity due to the huge amount of process power required to process even basic AI tasks, but they use a lot of water keeping the equipment cool. Not to mention if you dive really deep into the supply chain how the raw materials used in producing the hardware is often damaging.

Yes the AI summary from Google, assuming it is a LLM generating the response, is just as damaging for the environment.

u/ParameciaAntic • 1 points • 2025-05-12 15:02 UTC

Environmental issues aside, Google is much more likely to actually give you a **correct** answer than AI. Half the time it's crap.

u/Boundary-Interface • 1 points • 2025-05-12 14:58 UTC

The people who say stuff like that simply mean they're using a lot of electricity, but the truth of the matter is: that's not their fault. So, who's fault is it then? It's the electric company from whom they purchase their power from in the first place, that's who.

Electricity can be generated by a lot of different methods, but the easiest, laziest methods involve stuff that's probably bad for the environment. If there's any legitimacy to the argument that ChatGPT is bad for the environment, it's only as a technicality.

u/Overall-Purpose4781 • 10 points • 2025-05-12 14:54 UTC

Google the amount of electricity used by AI. It's astronomical. Most electricity is from fossil fuels. Hence the growth for more new, nuclear facilities.

u/deezzzznutz69420 • 0 points • 2025-05-12 14:57 UTC

Right. But if I google that, Google will also use AI to answer my question

u/C4Cupcake • 1 points • 2025-05-12 15:34 UTC

have you...forgotten how to actually google things? O.O

u/eggs-benedryl • 1 points • 2025-05-12 15:01 UTC

You can disable with extensions i'm sure.

If you want to use it, just use local LLM (ai) on your own PC. It avoids this issue as well as censorship at the cost of a less capable model (just don't ask it for statistics)

u/Ghigs • 3 points • 2025-05-12 15:29 UTC

An extension that just hides the output isn't changing how much CPU it took for Google.

u/akulowaty • -2 points • 2025-05-12 14:54 UTC

No difference. Both use tons of electricity which is bad for the environment